

SHAILESH RAVAL



UNFORGOTTEN HERO: Bhagwatsinh at Surajmalji's samadhi

The Sun Which Never Set

A town actively reveres a hero who waged a decade-long struggle against the British—125 years ago

■ By Uday Mahurkar

It is imperative for a marriage procession that passes through Mudeti in north Gujarat to stop by at the statue of Surajmalji Chauhan and hear a 10-minute recital of poems extolling his bravery. This is how the town of Mudeti has been paying tribute to the bravery of one of its former rulers—for the past 125 years.

Surajmalji, a 19th century Thakur of Mudeti, had risen in revolt when the British passed an order disallowing people from keeping weapons. At that time Mudeti was a tiny princely state of 24 villages. But regardless of the size of his turf, the Thakur questioned the British order, "How can Rajputs, whose duty is to fight, be asked to live without weapons?" When the British did not respond, he led an armed struggle which coincided with the revolt of 1857.

The British were forced to withdraw the order after a decade when the small but fierce rebellion could not be quelled. During the decade-long struggle, Surajmalji defeated the British forces twice in the Aravalli ranges. His name became a household name and served to inspire the locals as well as the Rajput land lords, many of whom sacrificed their lives in the battle. The Thakur was also a phil-



anthropist who was generous to the poor and had helped build a number of temples and wells. His popularity grew after the rebellion, and he was made a subject of many poems, which are now an important part of Rajasthani literature and are taught in several colleges. In Mudeti, he has turned from a ruler to its ruling deity.

Bhagwatsinh, a descendant of the Thakur quotes a local poet as saying that his illustrious ancestor would have made "an ideal ruler of Delhi".

Along with paying regular tribute to Surajmalji, Mudeti still remembers two other martyrs from that old rebellion: a Balochi named Shahid Khan, and Ratnaji Rathod, who left his new bride just to be a part of Surajmalji's ranks. Khan's tomb can be found even today in the Mudeti fortress behind the temple of the Ashapura goddess, the family deity of the then ruling family.

Surajmalji eventually died at a ripe age but he continues to live in the memory of the villagers to this day. Says Takhatsinh, the current Thakur of Mudeti says, "This is the ultimate proof of the fact that the deeds of the brave never go unsung and know no time barrier."

Revered as the 'sun of Mudeti', Surajmalji's tale, it seems, will never set.